Executive Summary

Australian enterprises and government agencies are racing to deploy agentic AI â€” autonomous systems that perceive, reason, act, and learn across enterprise environments. These systems introduce a fundamentally new attack surface that existing security frameworks (ISM, Essential Eight, NIST CSF, ISO 27001) were not designed to address. Agentic AI systems can execute multi-step workflows, invoke external tools, access enterprise data, generate code, and make operational decisions â€” each action a potential vector for compromise, data exfiltration, or unintended behaviour.

SHIELD-AI (Security and Holistic Integrity for Enterprise-Level Deployment of Artificial Intelligence) is a sovereign Australian framework purpose-built for securing agentic AI systems. It is:

- **Cloud-agnostic** â€” applies equally to AWS, Azure, Google Cloud, on-premise, and hybrid deployments
- **LLM-agnostic** â€” works with OpenAI, Anthropic, open-weight, or any model provider
- **Industry-agnostic** â€” relevant to banking, insurance, healthcare, critical infrastructure, and government
- **Fully aligned** with Australian regulatory frameworks including ASD ISM, Essential Eight, SOCI Act, APRA CPS 234/CPG 230, PSPF, and the Privacy Act 1988

The framework defines six security pillars, four maturity levels, and a comprehensive control set mapped to existing Australian frameworks. It is designed to be explainable to CISO, CRO, COO, CIO, GC, and board stakeholders in under 30 minutes â€” because security frameworks that cannot be explained to decision-makers are frameworks that will not be adopted.

Alongside the framework, this document defines a **definable business offering** â€” a tiered service model that an Australian IT security consultancy can take to market immediately, with clear pricing, delivery methodology, and competitive differentiation.

Part 1: The Case for an Australian Agentic AI Security Framework

1.1 The Agentic AI Security Gap

Traditional AI security has focused on model-level concerns: adversarial prompts, data poisoning, model inversion. Agentic AI introduces an entirely

new class of risk because the AI system is no longer a stateless inference endpoint â€” it is an **active computational agent** with:

- **Tool access** â€” ability to read/write databases, APIs, file systems, and execute code
- **Multi-step reasoning** â€” chains of actions that compound risk across steps
- **Memory** â€ persistent state across sessions, enabling data aggregation and inference
- **Autonomous action** â€ decisions made without human-in-the-loop approval
- **Identity delegation** â€ the agent acts on behalf of a user, with that userâ€™s privileges

The OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications (2025) identified prompt injection, insecure output handling, and excessive agency as critical risks. MITRE ATLAS catalogues attack techniques specific to AI systems. Both are valuable references, but neither provides a **comprehensive, implementable framework** that maps to Australian regulatory obligations.

1.2 Why Existing Frameworks Are Insufficient

Framework	Coverage	Agentic AI Gap
ASD ISM (1,081 controls)	Traditional infosec, system hardening, cloud	No AI-specific controls; no coverage of prompt injection, tool delegation, or agent identity
Essential Eight	Eight core mitigation strategies	Designed for commodity malware, not AI-specific threats
NIST AI RMF	AI risk management, governance	Not an implementable control framework; no technical controls
ISO/IEC 42001	AI management system	Management system standard, not security controls
OWASP LLM Top 10	AI-specific vulnerabilities	Threat taxonomy, not a control framework with maturity levels
SOCI Act/CIRMP	Critical infrastructure risk management	Obligations-based, not control-based

No existing framework addresses the unique combination of **AI-specific threats + Australian regulatory compliance + implementable technical controls + maturity progression**. SHIELD-AI fills precisely this gap.

1.3 The Australian Regulatory Landscape

An Australian framework must demonstrably align with the regulatory frameworks that Australian enterprises and government agencies are already required to comply with:

ASD Information Security Manual (ISM)

- 1,081 controls across 21 guideline sections
- Mandatory for Australian Government agencies (PSPF Policy 8)
- Increasingly referenced by regulated entities under SOCI and APRA
- March 2026 edition includes â€œGuidelines for secure AI system developmentâ€
- July 2026 publications on defending against AI-enabled attacks

Essential Eight (E8)

- Eight mitigation strategies at three maturity levels
- Maturity Level 1: Baseline (adversary uses commodity tradecraft)
- Maturity Level 2: Moderate (adversary invests more resources)
- Maturity Level 3: Advanced (adversary is highly resourced)
- Mandatory for Australian Government; recommended for all entities

Security of Critical Infrastructure (SOCI) Act 2018

- 11 critical infrastructure sectors
- Mandatory incident reporting (12 hours for critical, 72 hours for other)
- CIRMP (Critical Infrastructure Risk Management Program) rules
- Positive security obligations (duty to protect)

APRA CPS 234 / CPG 230

- Prudential standard for information security (APRA-regulated entities)
- Board accountability for security risk
- Mandatory incident notification within 72 hours
- CPG 230 provides guidance on managing security risks including AI

Protective Security Policy Framework (PSPF)

- Mandatory for Australian Government agencies
- Security governance, personnel security, physical security, information security
- Policy 8: Cyber security â€” references ISM compliance

Privacy Act 1988 / Australian Privacy Principles (APPs)

- 13 Australian Privacy Principles
- APP 11: Security of personal information
- OAIC guidance on AI and privacy (2024, updated 2025)
- Mandatory Notifiable Data Breaches (NDB) scheme

International Alignment

- EU AI Act (2024) â€” establishes risk categories for AI systems
- NIST AI RMF (January 2023) â€” risk management framework
- Singaporeâ€™s AI Verify â€” testing framework for AI
- UKâ€™s AI Safety Institute â€” testing and evaluation

SHIELD-AI provides a single unified framework that maps controls to all of these obligations simultaneously.

Part 2: The SHIELD-AI Framework

2.1 Core Principles

The framework is built on six principles:

1. **Sovereign by design.** Controls are mapped to Australian frameworks first, international frameworks second. An entity that complies with SHIELD-AI is demonstrably compliant with ISM, E8, SOCI, CPS 234, PSPF, and the Privacy Act.

2. **Defence in depth for agentic systems.** Agentic AI is not a single technology â€” it is a system of systems. Controls must cover the model, the data pipeline, the tool layer, the identity layer, and the monitoring layer.

3. **Least privilege for agents.** An AI agent must have the minimum set of tools, data access, and permissions required for its function â€” and no more. This principle extends to model weights, training data, inference endpoints, and tool registries.

4. **Verifiable by default.** Every control must be testable through automated means. Compliance is not a document â€” it is a set of passing assertions that can be validated in CI/CD pipelines.

5. **Proportional maturity.** Not every organisation needs Level 4 controls. The framework defines four maturity levels so entities can adopt controls proportional to their risk profile, threat model, and regulatory obligations.

6. **Evolvable architecture.** The AI security landscape changes monthly. The framework is designed for rapid updating â€” control additions do not require re-architecture of the framework itself.

2.2 The Six Pillars

SHIELD-AI defines six security pillars, each with its own control objectives, implementation guidance, and maturity progression. The pillars are ordered by the logical dependencies they introduce: model security is foundational,

identity and access determine the agentâ€™s scope of action, data security governs what it touches, tool and pipeline security controls what it invokes, monitoring detects when things go wrong, and governance ensures the whole system is accountable.

Pillar 1: Model Security (MS)

Objective: Secure the AI model itself â€” its weights, its training pipeline, its inference behaviour, and its supply chain.

Why this matters to the board: If your model is compromised, every decision the agent makes is suspect. A backdoored model in a financial services agent could approve fraudulent transactions for months before detection. Unlike traditional software, models can be poisoned during training, producing behaviour that appears normal until a specific trigger condition is met.

Control areas: - MS-01: Model weight protection (encryption at rest and in transit; HSM-backed key management preventing exfiltration of trained weights) - MS-02: Training data integrity (provenance tracking, data sanitisation, poison detection across the data pipeline) - MS-03: Supply chain security (model provenance verification, ML component SBOM, signed checkpoints preventing supply chain compromise) - MS-04: Adversarial robustness (prompt injection testing, jailbreak evaluation, automated red-teaming against known attack patterns) - MS-05: Model behaviour validation (output guardrails constraining model responses, content filtering for prohibited topics or data leakage, behavioural bounds enforcement) - MS-06: Model inventory and lineage tracking (catalogue all models, version history, deployment locations, training data provenance)

Implementation guidance (L2+): Deploy a model registry (e.g., MLflow, custom solution) that requires cryptographic signing at every stage â€” training data provenance, model checkpoint, deployment approval. Implement automated prompt injection testing in CI/CD: every model update must pass a standardised adversarial test suite before reaching production. Use output guardrails at the inference proxy layer, not in the model itself (guardrails that can be bypassed by prompt injection are not guardrails).

AU framework mappings: ISM (Guidelines for system hardening, procurement guidelines, system management), ISM â€œGuidelines for secure AI system developmentâ€ (March 2026 edition), ASD supply chain guidance for AI/ML (March 2026)

Pillar 2: Identity and Access (IAM)

Objective: Control what the agent can do, what it can access, and whose authority it acts under. This is the single highest-impact pillar for agentic AI security.

Why this matters to the board: The most common agentic AI security failure is excessive agency â€” an agent with the same access rights as its human user. If the human can read emails, edit documents, and submit

payments, and the agent inherits those permissions, a prompt injection can weaponise the entire access tree. This is not theoretical: the OWASP Top 10 for LLMs ranks Excessive Agency as the No.Â 2 risk.

Control areas: - IAM-01: Agent identity management (unique service identities per agent, not human credential sharing; each agent has a distinct, auditable identity) - IAM-02: Scope-bound delegation (tools and data access scoped to agent function; no wildcard permissions; agents cannot self-escalate) - IAM-03: Human oversight controls (approval gates for high-risk actions â€” data writes, financial transactions, user impersonation; break-glass mechanisms with audit trail) - IAM-04: Credential isolation (agent credentials stored separately from human credentials; hardware-backed for L3+; credential rotation automatically triggered on compromise) - IAM-05: Just-in-time access (ephemeral credentials with automatic revocation after session expiry; no persistent standing access for agent identities) - IAM-06: Cross-session boundary enforcement (agent memory and session state must not share credentials across sessions; each session is an independent identity context)

Implementation guidance (L2+): Implement a policy-as-code engine (e.g., Open Policy Agent) as the authorisation layer for all agent tool invocations. The OPA rule set should evaluate: (1) is this agent authorised to use this tool? (2) is this agent acting within its scope for this data category? (3) does this action require human approval? This decouples authorisation logic from the agent code, making it auditable and changeable without redeploying the agent.

AU framework mappings: ISM (Guidelines for system management â€” privileged access, user identification and authentication), Essential Eight (Restrict Administrative Privileges, Multi-factor Authentication, User Application Hardening), PSPF (Personnel Security, Information Security â€” access control)

Pillar 3: Data Security (DS)

Objective: Protect data at every stage of the agentic AI lifecycle â€” ingestion, processing, storage, inference, and memory. Agentic AI multiplies data risk because the agent aggregates data across multiple sources during a session and may persist that aggregation in memory.

Why this matters to the board: Agentic AI systems can unintentionally aggregate data from multiple sources in a single session â€” cross-referencing customer records, financial transactions, and internal communications â€” creating a consolidated view that would itself be a protected dataset. The Privacy Act 1988 (APP 11) requires entities to protect personal information from misuse, interference, loss, and unauthorised access, modification, or disclosure. An agent that violates this creates personal liability for directors.

Control areas: - DS-01: Data classification and labelling (input and output data classified per PSPF/ISM/GovERP schema; automated tagging at ingestion) - DS-02: Inference data protection (data in prompts and responses

encrypted end-to-end; inference endpoints use TLS 1.3 minimum) - DS-03: Memory sanitisation (agent must not persist classified or sensitive data beyond session lifetime; memory wiped between sessions) - DS-04: Data minimisation (only the minimum data required for task performance is exposed to the model; no bulk data access; field-level filtering in the retrieval layer) - DS-05: Training data governance (data lineage tracking, consent verification for personal data, retention limits on training datasets) - DS-06: Output validation (agent outputs must not leak training data, PII, sensitive business context, or system prompts; automated scanning for data leakage)

Implementation guidance (L2+): Implement a retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) security layer that filters data at the retrieval stage, not at the model stage. The RAG pipeline should: classify documents before indexing, apply attribute-based access control (ABAC) at retrieval time, redact sensitive fields before they reach the model context, and strip system prompts from model outputs. This ensures that even if the model is compromised by prompt injection, the data exposed is limited to what the agentâ€™s scope permits.

AU framework mappings: Privacy Act 1988 (APP 11 â€” security of personal information, APP 5 â€” collection, APP 6 â€” use and disclosure), ISM (Guidelines for data transfers, media, cryptography), SOCI Act (CIRMP data protection obligations), PSPF (Information Security â€” sensitive and classified information)

Pillar 4: Tool and Pipeline Security (TP)

Objective: Secure the tools, APIs, plugins, and execution pipelines that the agent invokes. In agentic AI, the agentâ€™s power comes from its tools â€” and its risk comes from the same source. Every tool is a potential attack surface.

Why this matters to the board: A compromised agent with access to a database query tool is a data breach vector. A compromised agent with access to a code execution tool is a supply chain attack vector. Tools are the difference between a chatbot that talks and an agent that acts â€” and each action capability is a liability if not secured. The SolarWinds supply chain compromise cost impacted organisations an estimated $12B+; an agentic supply chain compromise through an unsecured tool pipeline would have similar magnitude.

Control areas: - TP-01: Tool inventory and registry (all agent-accessible tools must be registered, versioned, and security-approved before any agent can invoke them) - TP-02: Tool access control (least-privilege tool assignment per agent identity; tools must authenticate the agent, not delegate to the humanâ€™s session) - TP-03: API gateway security (rate limiting, payload validation, schema enforcement, and audit logging on every agent-facing API endpoint) - TP-04: Tool output validation (tool outputs must be structurally validated and sanitised before being fed back into the agent context â€” prevent tool output injection) - TP-05: Pipeline integrity (CI/CD pipelines for agent deployments must be signed, attested, and gated

by security validation gates) - TP-06: Dependency scanning (all libraries, model dependencies, and tools continuously scanned for known vulnerabilities; automated blocking for critical-severity findings)

Implementation guidance (L2+): Deploy a tool gateway / sidecar proxy that sits between the agent and every external tool. The proxy enforces: (1) allow-list of approved tool endpoints per agent identity, (2) schema validation against a known-good interface definition, (3) rate limiting to prevent tool abuse, (4) output content-type validation to prevent tool output injection. The proxy generates an audit event for every tool invocation â€” who, what, when, input, output â€” and can fail-closed if the audit destination is unreachable.

AU framework mappings: ISM (Guidelines for gateways, networking, software development, system management), Essential Eight (Patch Applications, Patch Operating Systems, Application Control), SOCI Act (CIRMP technology security obligations)

Pillar 5: Monitoring, Logging, and Incident Response (MIR)

Objective: Detect and respond to security incidents involving agentic AI systems. Traditional monitoring was designed for static applications and known attack signatures. Agentic AI monitoring must detect behavioural anomalies, not just signature matches.

Why this matters to the board: An agentic AI compromise can execute its entire attack chain in seconds â€” from initial prompt injection to data exfiltration â€” faster than a human can detect. Without AI-specific monitoring, you will not know an agent has been compromised until the data is already exfiltrated. The SOCI Act requires critical infrastructure entities to report incidents within 12 hours. Without monitoring controls, you cannot meet that obligation.

Control areas: - MIR-01: Agent activity logging (all agent actions logged â€” every tool invocation, data access, decision, and error; logs include agent identity, session ID, tool, input summary, output summary) - MIR-02: Behavioural anomaly detection (baseline per-agent behaviour established over training period; alerts on deviation â€” unusual tool, unusual data access pattern, unusual frequency) - MIR-03: Prompt audit log (capture sanitised prompt/response pairs for forensic analysis; sensitive fields redacted before logging but recoverable for incident response) - MIR-04: Incident response playbooks (AI-specific IR procedures distinct from general IR: prompt injection containment, model rollback, tool access revocation, session invalidation) - MIR-05: Mandatory reporting integration (automated triggers for SOCI 12-hour and APRA 72-hour notification windows; pre-populated incident report templates) - MIR-06: Forensic readiness (immutable logs written to append-only storage; full session reconstruction capability including tool call chains and model responses)

Implementation guidance (L2+): Deploy agent telemetry as a structured event stream (e.g., OTLP, structured JSON to a SIEM platform). Each event

should include: agent ID, session ID, timestamp, action type (tool_call, data_access, model_inference, decision), action target, action result, and a correlation ID that ties the event to the human-initiating session. Build at least two behavioural baselines: per-agent (what is normal for this specific agent) and per-agent-class (what is normal for this type of agent). Deviation from per-agent baseline is a high-confidence alert; deviation from per-agent-class baseline only is a medium-confidence alert.

AU framework mappings: SOCI Act (s.30B mandatory incident reporting â€” 12 hours for critical, 72 hours for other), APRA CPS 234 (s.3(c) incident notification within 72 hours), ISM (Guidelines for system monitoring, cyber security incidents), Privacy Act (Notifiable Data Breaches scheme)

Pillar 6: Governance and Risk Management (GRM)

Objective: Establish the organisational structures, policies, and risk processes for safe agentic AI. This is the pillar that makes all other pillars sustainable â€” without governance, technical controls erode over time.

Why this matters to the board: APRA CPS 234 explicitly makes the Board responsible for information security. In an age of agentic AI, this means the Board is responsible for AI security. Without a governance structure that documents who decides, who approves, and who is accountable, Board members cannot discharge their duty of care. The Privacy Actâ€™s accountability principle (APP 1) requires entities to have practices in place to manage privacy risks â€” and agentic AI introduces privacy risks that existing practices do not cover.

Control areas: - GRM-01: AI governance body (chartered committee with CISO, CRO, General Counsel, data owner, and AI lead; terms of reference that include agentic AI approval authority) - GRM-02: AI risk register (distinct from general risk register; AI-specific threat taxonomy covering model, tool, data, identity, and pipeline risks) - GRM-03: Ethical use policy (acceptable use boundaries for agentic AI: what agents can and cannot do; human-in-the-loop requirements by risk tier; transparency obligations) - GRM-04: Third-party AI risk management (vendor security assessment for model providers, tool providers, and infrastructure; contractual obligations for security controls; right-to-audit clauses) - GRM-05: Regulatory mapping and compliance reporting (automated mapping to ISM, E8, SOCI, CPS 234, PSPF, Privacy Act; quarterly compliance posture reports) - GRM-06: Board and executive reporting (standardised dashboard for AI security posture: maturity scores per pillar, open findings, regulatory compliance status, risk acceptance decisions)

Implementation guidance (L2+): Implement a policy-as-code compliance engine that continuously tests agentic AI deployments against SHIELD-AI controls. Each control is expressed as a machine-readable assertion (e.g., Rego policy for OPA, or an automated test in the CI/CD pipeline). Results feed into a compliance dashboard that shows: (1) which controls pass/fail per agent, (2) trend over time (is posture improving?), (3) regulatory exposure by framework (what would a regulator find?), (4) open risk

acceptances with expiry dates. This replaces the traditional â€œannual auditâ€ model with continuous compliance verification.

AU framework mappings: APRA CPS 234 (s.2 Board accountability for information security), PSPF (Security Governance â€” Policy 1, Policy 2, Policy 8), SOCI Act (CIRMP governance obligations), Privacy Act (APP 1 â€” accountability, APP 12 â€ access to information), ISM (Guidelines for cyber security roles, documentation)

2.3 Maturity Model

SHIELD-AI defines four maturity levels, consistent with ISMâ€™s implementation approach and the Essential Eightâ€™s maturity model:

Level	Name	Description	Typical Entity
L1	Initial	Ad-hoc AI security; basic controls for model deployment; no formal governance	Startups, AI experimentation, PoCs
L2	Managed	Documented controls for priority AI systems; basic monitoring; vendor assessment for model providers	Small-medium enterprises, early adopters
L3	Defined	Enterprise-wide AI security program; automated controls; integrated monitoring and IR; full regulatory mapping	Regulated entities, government agencies, large enterprises
L4	Optimised	Continuous improvement; AI-specific threat intelligence; automated red-teaming; proactive control evolution	Critical infrastructure, national security, top-tier regulated entities

Maturity Progression by Pillar

Control Area	L1	L2	L3	L4
MS (Model)	Basic model inventory	Supply chain verification	Adversarial testing programme	Automated red-teaming
IAM (Identity)	Shared credentials	Per-agent service accounts	JIT access, approval gates	Continuous credential rotation
DS (Data)				

Control Area	L1	L2	L3	L4
	Basic data classification	Memory sanitisation enforced	End-to-end inference encryption	Real-time data leak detection
TP (Tools)	Informal tool list	Tool registry with access control	API gateway with schema validation	Automated dependency scanning
MIR (Monitoring)	Basic logging	Structured audit logs	Anomaly detection, IR playbooks	AI-specific SIEM integration
GRM (Governance)	No formal governance	AI risk register established	Board reporting, regulatory mapping	Automated compliance attestation

2.4 Regulatory Mapping

A core differentiator of SHIELD-AI is its explicit, auditable mapping to the frameworks Australian organisations must comply with. The following table shows a representative sample:

SHIELD-AI Control	ISM Ref	E8 Ref	SOCI Act	CPS 234	Privacy Act
MS-01: Model weight protection	ISM-1xxx (cryptography)	-	CIRMP s.4(a)	s.3(b)	APP 11
IAM-01: Agent identity	Guidelines for system management	Restrict Admin Privs	-	s.3(b)	-
IAM-02: Scope-bound delegation	Guidelines for system management	-	CIRMP s.4(b)	s.3(a)	-
DS-01: Data classification	Guidelines for data transfers	-	-	s.3(a)	APP 5, 6
DS-02: Inference data protection	Guidelines for cryptography	MFA	-	s.3(b)	APP 11
DS-06: Output validation	Guidelines for software dev	-	-	-	APP 11
TP-01: Tool registry	Guidelines for gateways	Patch Apps	CIRMP s.4(c)	s.3(b)	-
MIR-01: Activity logging	Guidelines for system monitoring	-	s.30B(5)(a)	s.3(c)	NDB
MIR-05: Mandatory reporting	Guidelines for incident mgmt	-	s.30B(5)(c)	s.3(c)	NDB

SHIELD-AI Control	ISM Ref	E8 Ref	SOCI Act	CPS 234	Privacy Act
GRM-01: AI governance body	Guidelines for cyber security roles	-	CIRMP s.4(d)	s.2	APP 1

> **Note:** A full control-by-control mapping to all 1,081 ISM controls, 24 Essential Eight maturity descriptors, 11 SOCI obligation categories, CPS 234 criteria, and 13 APPs is maintained as a separate reference document. This summary table demonstrates the mapping methodology.

Part 3: The Business Offering

3.1 Service Overview

SHIELD-AI is delivered as a **professional services and managed assurance offering** by the Australian IT security consultancy. It is not a software product â€” it is an **expert-driven framework implementation service** that combines deep Australian regulatory knowledge, AI security expertise, and hands-on technical delivery.

The offering is structured as three tiers:

SHIELD-AI Lite â€” Quick Start ($25,000â€“$45,000)

Best for: Organisations experimenting with AI, running 1-3 pilots, needing to understand their exposure.

Deliverables: - AI security posture assessment (current state across 6 pillars) - Regulatory exposure report (gap analysis against applicable frameworks) - Tiered action plan (30/60/90-day remediation roadmap) - One-hour board summary briefing

Engagement model: 2-3 weeks, remote, 80% assessment + 20% reporting. Light-touch client involvement (2-3 stakeholder interviews).

At the end, the client knows: - What agentic AI risks they have - Which regulatory obligations apply - What they need to fix first - Whether they need SHIELD-AI Standard

SHIELD-AI Standard â€” Enterprise Programme ($120,000â€“$250,000)

Best for: Regulated entities, government agencies, and large enterprises deploying agentic AI in production.

Deliverables: - Full SHIELD-AI gap assessment across all 6 pillars (4 weeks) - Control implementation (policy creation, technical control

deployment, IAM reconfiguration) - Regulatory mapping report (automated ISM/E8/SOCI/CPS 234 alignment) - Agentic AI security architecture (reference architecture tailored to client environment) - Tool integration (SIEM enrichment, SOAR playbooks, CI/CD guardrails) - Training (developer secure-coding for agentic AI, operator IR) - 6-month managed compliance assurance (quarterly posture reviews, advisory hours)

Engagement model: 12-16 weeks active delivery + 6 months assurance. Dedicated engagement lead, 2-3 consultants. Weekly stakeholder cadence.

At the end, the client has: - Agentic AI systems operating at SHIELD-AI Maturity Level 3 - Auditable regulatory compliance - Ongoing assurance without hiring full-time AI security specialists

SHIELD-AI Enterprise â€” Strategic Partnership ($400,000â€“$800,000+ per annum)

Best for: Critical infrastructure operators, top-tier banks, national security agencies, multi-entity government deployments.

Deliverables: - Everything in Standard, plus: - Dedicated AI security architect (embedded in client team, 2-3 days/week) - Continuous red-teaming (automated adversarial testing, quarterly human-led campaigns) - AI threat intelligence feed (curated intelligence on AI-specific TTPs, zero-day prompt attacks) - Custom control development (bespoke guardrails, tool validators, anomaly detectors) - Regulatory advocacy support (preparation for APRA/ASD/OAIC inquiries, exam support) - Cross-entity governance (framework operating across multiple business units, agencies, or subsidiaries) - Vendor security assessment programme (ongoing evaluation of model providers, tool vendors, infrastructure)

Engagement model: Ongoing partnership. Annual retainer with quarterly health checks and monthly operational reviews.

At the end of Year 1, the client has: - Agentic AI at SHIELD-AI Maturity Level 4 - Industry-leading AI security posture - Regulatory confidence for audit and examination - Strategic advantage over peers who have not addressed agentic AI risk

3.2 Delivery Methodology

SHIELD-AI engagements follow a five-phase methodology:

Phase 1: Discover (Weeks 1-2)

- Inventory all AI systems, models, tools, and data pipelines
- Map agentic workflows and tool delegation chains
- Identify regulatory obligations (which frameworks apply, at what maturity)
- Stakeholder interviews (CISO, AI lead, data owners, risk, legal)
- **Output:** AI security inventory + regulatory obligation map

Phase 2: Assess (Weeks 3-4)

- Evaluate each AI system against the six SHIELD-AI pillars
- Score current maturity per control area
- Identify critical gaps (regulatory non-compliance, existential risks)
- Prioritise remediation by risk level and business impact
- **Output:** SHIELD-AI gap assessment report with maturity scores

Phase 3: Design (Weeks 5-8)

- Architecture design for controls (tool registry, API gateway, IAM, monitoring)
- Policy and procedure drafting (acceptable use, incident response, governance)
- Regulatory mapping documentation
- Implementation roadmap (sequenced by dependency and risk reduction)
- **Output:** Target-state architecture + implementation plan

Phase 4: Implement (Weeks 9-16)

- Technical control deployment (IAG, API security, logging, monitoring)
- Policy enactment (board-approved AI security policy, governance charter)
- Tool integration (SIEM, SOAR, CI/CD pipeline, compliance reporting)
- Training delivery (developer, operator, executive)
- **Output:** Deployed controls + trained teams + operational runbooks

Phase 5: Assure (Ongoing)

- Quarterly posture reviews
- Monthly advisory hours (Standard) or embedded architect (Enterprise)
- Regulatory change monitoring (ISM updates, new AI regulation, OAIC guidance)
- Incident response support (AI-specific)
- Annual re-assessment and maturity progression
- **Output:** Continuous assurance + maturity progression reports

3.3 Competitive Advantage

Why a client chooses SHIELD-AI over alternatives:

Competitor Type	Their Offer	SHIELD-AI Advantage
Big 4 (Deloitte, PwC, EY, KPMG)	Generic AI risk advisory, often framework-agnostic	Deep AU regulatory specificity; implementable technical controls (not just decks); lower cost point for equivalent depth

Competitor Type	Their Offer	SHIELD-AI Advantage
Boutique AI consultancies	AI strategy, model development	Security-focused (not build-focused); regulatory expertise; maturity model for security progression
Global cybersecurity firms (Mandiant, CrowdStrike, Accenture)	Incident response, managed detection	Preventive control framework specific to agentic AI; AU regulatory mapping; smaller engagement minimums
Cloud providers (AWS/ Azure/GCP)	Platform-native AI security features	Cloud-agnostic; covers multi-cloud/hybrid; independent assessment (no vendor lock-in); covers non-cloud deployment
In-house teams	Self-built controls	Access to deep AI security specialisation they cannot hire for; framework reuse across engagements; peer benchmarking

Unique differentiators:

1. **Sovereign Australian framework.** Not a US framework adapted for Australia. Built from the ground up for ISM, E8, SOCI, CPS 234, PSPF, and the Privacy Act. No translation layer needed. When a client asks â€œdoes this satisfy my ISM obligations?â€�, the answer is a control-by-control mapping, not a hand-wavy reference.

2. **Agentic-AI-specific, not general AI.** Most competitor frameworks address â€œAIâ€� as a monolith â€” one set of controls for chatbots, RAG systems, recommendation engines, and autonomous agents. SHIELD-AI is specifically designed for autonomous, tool-using, multi-step reasoning agents â€” the highest-risk, highest-complexity deployment pattern that existing frameworks were not designed to cover.

3. **Implementable controls, not just policies.** Every control area includes technical implementation guidance (IAM agent identification via OPA, RAG security via ABAC at retrieval, monitoring via structured telemetry streams), not just policy language. Clients leave with configured tool registries, API gateways, guardrails, and test suites â€” not a PDF binder that sits on a shelf.

4. **Maturity progression, not binary compliance.** Clients can start at their level and grow. The framework does not demand Level 4 from every organisation. This makes it accessible to AI experimenters (who need L1-L2 to manage risk while proving value) and credible for critical infrastructure operators (who need L3-L4 for regulatory compliance). The maturity model also gives the consultancy a natural upsell path.

5. **Demonstrable compliance.** The regulatory mapping is explicit and auditable. When the regulator asks â€œhow are you securing your AI systems?â€, the answer is not a PowerPoint â€” it is a documented control framework with passing assertions mapped to ISM control IDs, Essential Eight maturity descriptors, SOCI obligations, and CPS 234 criteria. This eliminates the anxiety that keeps CISO up at night.

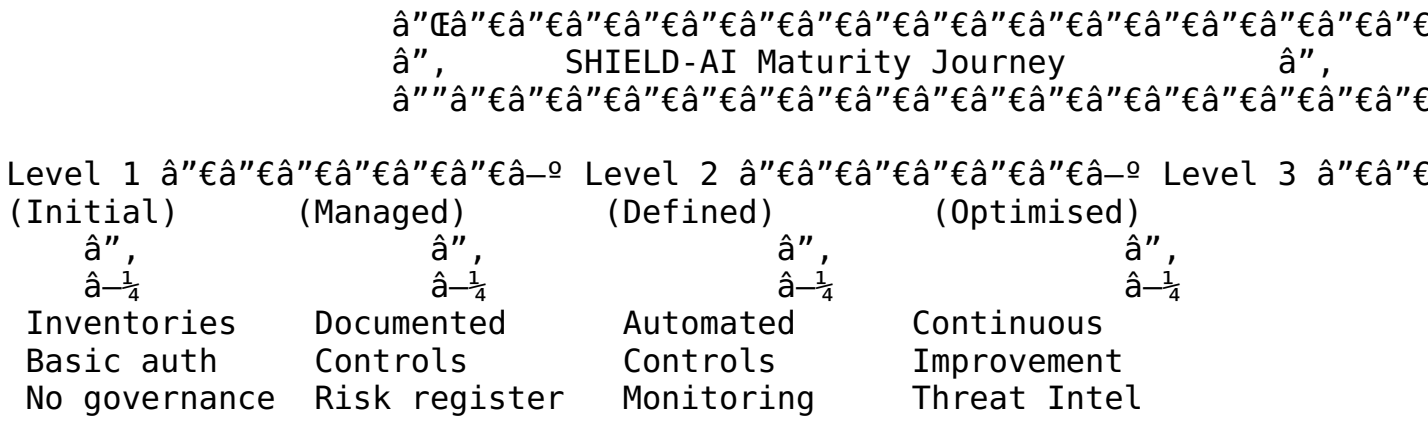
6. **Australian data sovereignty.** The framework assumes Australian data sovereignty requirements (Privacy Act, PSPF, SOCI, OAIC guidance) as default, not special cases. International data flows, cross-border model inference, and global cloud deployments are handled as documented exceptions with compensating controls â€” not the other way around.

7. **Consultancy ecosystem advantage.** Because the consultancy delivers both the assessment AND the implementation, there is no â€œreport handoffâ€ gap where findings go unactioned. The same team that identifies the gap designs and deploys the fix. This eliminates the most common failure mode of security consulting: excellent reports that gather dust.

Part 4: Implementation Roadmap

4.1 Framework Maturity Journey

An organisation adopting SHIELD-AI follows a progressive implementation journey:



Typical timeline by tier:

Starting Level	Target Level	Typical Duration	Investment
L1 (None)	L2 (Managed)	3-4 months	$120Kâ€“$200K (Standard)
L1 (None)	L3 (Defined)	8-12 months	$300Kâ€“$500K (Standard + follow-on)
L2 (Managed)	L3 (Defined)	4-6 months	

Starting Level	Target Level	Typical Duration	Investment
			$150Kâ€“$250K (Targeted uplift)
L3 (Defined)	L4 (Optimised)	12+ months	$400K+/year (Enterprise)

4.2 Market Entry Strategy for the Consultancy

Phase 1: Capability Building (Months 1-3)

- Train 3-5 consultants in SHIELD-AI methodology
- Develop assessment tooling (automated control checking scripts, maturity scoring engine)
- Create marketing collateral (one-pager, presentation deck, proposal template)
- Deliver 1-2 pro-bono or discounted Lite engagements (case study generation)
- Build reference regulatory mapping (detailed ISM/E8/CPS 234 control cross-reference)

Phase 2: Initial Commercialisation (Months 4-9)

- Target existing client relationships with SHIELD-AI Lite (warm introduction, low risk)
- Convert 3-5 Lite engagements into Standard engagements
- Develop 2-3 case studies with named client outcomes (sanitised where required)
- Present at industry events (AusCERT, AISA, AFRCyber, ACSC conferences)
- Establish referral partnerships with:
  - Law firms (AI governance, privacy, regulatory advice)
  - Cloud partners (AWS/Azure/GCC/GCP professional services)
  - AI platform vendors (clients buying AI need security)

Phase 3: Scale (Months 10-24)

- Hire 3-5 additional consultants (train in SHIELD-AI methodology)
- Develop Enterprise offering with 1-2 anchor clients
- Build IP: SHIELD-AI assessment platform (SaaS for continuous posture monitoring)
- Publish annual SHIELD-AI State of Agentic AI Security report (thought leadership)
- Expand to New Zealand (parallel regulatory environment)
- Achieve ASD Partner Program certification (credibility for government clients)

4.3 Financial Model

Metric	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
Lite engagements	8-10	12-15	15-20
Standard engagements	3-5	6-8	10-12
Enterprise clients	0-1	1-3	3-5
Total revenue (est.)	$600Kâ€“$1.2M	$1.5Mâ€“$3.0M	$3.5Mâ€“$6.0M
Consultant headcount	3-5	6-10	12-18
Gross margin	50-60%	55-65%	60-70%

4.4 Case for Investment

For the client (why they buy):

Risk Scenario	Cost of Inaction	SHIELD-AI Cost to Mitigate
AI system exfiltrates customer PII	$1.78M avg NDB breach cost (OAIC 2025) + regulatory action + reputation	$25Kâ€“$120K (Lite or Standard)
Prompt injection causes financial loss	Loss magnitude Ã— agent transaction limit + brand damage	$120Kâ€“$250K (Standard)
SOCI-reportable incident involving AI	Penalties up to $2.2M per obligation + mandatory public notification	$250Kâ€“$400K (Standard + assurance)
APRA regulator inquiry into AI security	Enforcement action + remediation direction + remediation costs	$120Kâ€“$250K (Standard with regulatory add-on)
Board liability for AI-related harm	Director duty of care + civil penalties	$120Kâ€“$250K (Standard with governance focus)

For the consultancy (why they invest in building this):

- **First-mover advantage in a nascent market.** Few Australian consultancies have a credible, documented, Australian-specific agentic AI security framework.
- **High demand trajectory.** Agentic AI adoption is accelerating faster than security capability development. The gap between deployment and protection is widening.
- **Regulatory tailwind.** Every new AU AI regulation (mandatory guardrails, AI Safety Commissioner, OAIC guidance) increases the obligation on entities to demonstrate AI security.
- **Recurring revenue model.** Assurance engagements create ongoing revenue beyond initial implementation. Standard clients convert to Enterprise over time.

- **IP value.** The SHIELD-AI framework itself has value as intellectual property â€” assessment methodology, control mappings, maturity scoring, reference architectures.

Part 5: Governance and Evolution

5.1 Framework Governance

SHIELD-AI is maintained by the consulting practiceâ€™s Security Architecture Practice Lead, overseen by a **Framework Steering Group** comprising:

- Practice Lead (Chair)
- Technical AI Security Lead
- Regulatory Compliance Lead
- Client Advisory Board (2-3 senior client CISOs)
- External Advisor (academic AI safety researcher or ex-regulator)

The steering group meets quarterly to review: - Regulatory changes (ISM updates, new legislation, OAIC/APRA guidance) - Threat landscape evolution (new AI attack techniques, vulnerability classes) - Framework adoption feedback (what works, what needs refinement) - Control additions or modifications

5.2 Versioning and Release Cadence

Version	Trigger	Process
Patch (v1.0 â†’ v1.1)	ISM update, minor control refinement	Practice lead approval, updated mapping table
Minor (v1.x â†’ v2.0)	New regulatory obligation, new attack vector class	Steering group review, 4-week consultation
Major (v1.x â†’ v2.x)	Fundamental framework change	8-week consultation including select client feedback

5.3 Certification Path

For clients requiring formal recognition: - SHIELD-AI Practitioner (internal team member trained in framework application) - SHIELD-AI Assessor (authorised to perform independent SHIELD-AI assessments) - SHIELD-AI Certified Organisation (organisation assessed at target maturity level)

Certification is optional â€” most clients will use the framework for self-assessment and regulatory compliance without formal certification.

Appendix A: Glossary

Term	Definition
Agentic AI	An AI system that can autonomously perceive, reason, act, and learn across multi-step workflows with tool access
Tool delegation	The mechanism by which an agent invokes external tools, APIs, or systems
Prompt injection	An attack where crafted input causes an AI model to behave outside intended parameters
Agent identity	The digital identity under which an agent operates, distinct from the human user who initiated it
Control	A safeguard, policy, or technical mechanism that mitigates a specific security risk
Maturity level	A defined stage of security capability, from ad-hoc (L1) to continuously optimised (L4)
Guardrail	Technical controls that constrain model behaviour, typically at inference time
Agent SBOM	A software bill of materials for an agentic AI system, including model, tools, libraries, and pipeline

Appendix B: Quick-Reference Pillar Summary

Pillar	Focus	Key Question Stakeholders Should Ask
MS	Model	â€œDo we know where our models come from and how they behave?â€
IAM	Identity	â€œCan our agents do anything the user can do? â€
DS	Data	â€œIs our data exposed to the model, and is it protected?â€
TP	Tools	â€œWhat tools can our agents call, and is that controlled?â€
MIR	Monitoring	â€œWould we know if an agent was compromised? â€
GRM	Governance	â€œWho is accountable for AI security, and can they demonstrate it?â€

SHIELD-AI v1.0 â€” July 2026 Authored by the Security Architecture Practice For enquiries: practice-lead@consultancy.example.com